

M. Cecilia Ramírez-Michelena

Applied Economist | Research & Policy Project Management
Barcelona, open to relocation | Spanish and Uruguayan citizen

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Professional Summary

Applied economist and final-stage Ph.D. candidate in Economics with experience developing and managing applied research projects across Spain, the United States, and Uruguay. My work combines applied microeconomic research with randomized evaluations, large administrative and survey datasets, field implementation, staff supervision, budget management, and sustained collaboration with public institutions. I have experience taking research projects from design through implementation, working with multidisciplinary teams and institutional partners, and communicating findings to both academic and policy audiences. Research interests include education, labor markets, gender inequality, and social policy.

Core Competencies: Research project management; applied economic research; randomized evaluations and causal inference; research design and implementation; staff supervision and field-team management; public-sector stakeholder engagement; administrative and survey microdata; budget and grant management; research and policy writing.

Professional Experience

Institut d'Economia de Barcelona, Universitat de Barcelona

Predoctoral Researcher

01/2023 – Present

Barcelona, Spain

- Conduct doctoral research in education and labor economics on gender inequality, educational choices, and labor-market trajectories. My dissertation combines administrative microdata, survey data, randomized field experiments, and quasi-experimental methods to study school electrification in rural Uruguay, the gender wage gap and child penalty in Spain, and the role of students' abilities in shaping gender gaps in STEM choices.
- Building on findings from my research on gender gaps in STEM, conceived and proposed a school-based randomized information intervention in Catalonia targeting how students interpret their relative academic strengths, which I am now developing with my co-authors for implementation in December 2026. The intervention has particular potential to affect high-achieving female students at the margin of choosing STEM and was designed to be low-cost and scalable. Independently prepared the successful application to the *Women and Science Programme* at Paris Dauphine–PSL grant and lead preparation for implementation, including treatment and survey design, school engagement, ethics and data protection approvals, preregistration, implementation planning, and budget management.

Education Policy Analytics Lab, College of Education, University of Washington

Research Associate

09/2018 – 09/2019

Seattle, United States

- Worked in a research-practice partnership with Seattle Public Schools, the largest K–12 public school district in Washington State, analyzing administrative data on teacher effectiveness, absenteeism, staffing, and retention, particularly in schools serving disadvantaged students.
- Worked with senior district leadership, analysts, school administrators, program managers, and teachers' union representatives to turn operational concerns into empirical questions that could be addressed with available data, incorporate institutional knowledge into the analysis, and communicate findings and their limitations through internal reports, technical notes, and presentations for district decision-makers.

Center for Research in Applied Economics, Universidad de Montevideo

Research Assistant and Field Leader

06/2015 – 07/2018

Montevideo, Uruguay

- Contributed to the design and led field implementation of two randomized evaluations with highly vulnerable populations: a social-benefit and labor-inclusion intervention with more than 300 informal street workers and a digital-inclusion intervention with more than 120 older adults in public long-term care. Across both projects, worked on intervention and survey design, data-quality monitoring, quantitative analysis, and research outputs; co-author of a working paper from the first evaluation and of a peer-reviewed publication from the second.
- For the informal-worker evaluation, piloted the intervention and recruited and coordinated ten social workers responsible for treatment delivery and surveys. Worked closely with them to improve outreach, identify implementation bottlenecks, and adjust field procedures, while coordinating operational issues and data access with a specialized police unit that already worked with this population and with the social security administration.
- For the older-adult evaluation, piloted the intervention, recruited and trained more than 50 volunteers, matched volunteers to participants, and hired an on-site coordinator to supervise daily activities. Worked regularly with hospital leadership and clinical staff to resolve implementation problems, ensure completion of medical and cognitive assessments, and preserve the randomized design when institutional priorities conflicted with it.

Education

Universitat de Barcelona, Barcelona, Spain	
Ph.D. candidate in Economics	Thesis submission expected 10/2026
Dissertation: <i>Essays on gender inequality, educational choices, and labor-market pathways</i> .	
Supervisors: Profs. Lidia Farré and Andreu Arenas.	
Visiting doctoral student, Teachers College, Columbia University, New York, US	Fall 2026
Visiting doctoral student, Paris School of Economics, Paris, France	June 2026
University of Washington, Seattle, United States	
M.Ed. in Educational Foundations, Leadership, and Policy Studies	2021
Specialization in <i>Organizational and Policy Studies</i>	
M.A. in Economics	2021
Universidad de Montevideo, Montevideo, Uruguay	
M.A. in Economics	2020
B.A. in Economics	2016
B.A. in Management and Business Administration	2016

Selected Grants & Fellowships

Fellowships	Doctoral Fellowship, Fundación Ramón Areces (2023–2027). Fulbright Scholarship for Graduate Studies, Fulbright Commission (2018–2020).
Research Grants	Women and Science Programme, Paris Dauphine–PSL University – EUR 10,000 (2025).

Technical Skills & Languages

Methods & Data	Advanced causal inference methods; randomized evaluations; discrete choice experiments; survey design. Linked administrative records; survey, experimental, and longitudinal microdata.
Research & Project Management	Project design and implementation; fieldwork planning and protocols; staff recruitment, training, and supervision; implementation monitoring and troubleshooting; budget management; stakeholder and institutional coordination; grant applications.
Research Outputs	Academic papers; funding applications; technical notes; analytical reports; policy-facing materials; stakeholder and academic presentations.
Software	Stata (advanced); R and Python (working knowledge); Microsoft Office; LaTeX; Git/GitHub.
Languages	Spanish, native; English, fluent; Catalan, intermediate.

Selected Research

• Abilities and Career Choices: Addressing the Gender Gap in STEM Fields. With A. Arenas and L. Farré. Working Paper. Presented at BRIDGE Economics of Education Workshop (KU Leuven) and SEHO Annual Meeting, 2025.	
• Educational Gains from School Electrification in Rural Areas. With M. Blanco and N. D’Agosti. Working Paper. Presented at European Association of Labour Economists (EALE), 2024.	
• Strategies to Increase the Take-up of Social Benefits: Evidence from a Field Experiment. With A. Cid, J.M. Cabrera, and M. Blanco. Working Paper. Presented at the Uruguayan Central Bank.	
• The Evolution of the Child Penalty and the Gender Wage Gap in Spain. With A. Arenas and L. Farré. Working Paper.	
• Tablets for Deeply Disadvantaged Older Adults: Challenges in Long-term Care Facilities. With A. Cid, R. Sotelo, and M. Leguisamo. <i>International Journal of Human-Computer Studies</i> (2020).	

Student Supervision & Teaching Experience

Universitat de Barcelona – Instructor and B.A. Thesis Advisor, Department of Economics.	
IFSA Barcelona – Lecturer.	Winter 2026
University of Washington – Instructor, Department of Spanish and Portuguese Studies.	Fall 2020 – Spring 2021
Universidad de Montevideo – Teaching Assistant, Department of Economics.	Fall 2014 – Spring 2015